THE DAR AL-SULTANAT

When Akbar set off from Attock Fort on the Indus in 1586, it was believed that he was finally returning to the capital at Fatehpur Sikri. Instead, the Mughal retinue stopped at Lahore and Akbar would remain in the city for a dozen years, anchoring it forever in the Mughal imagination and bolting it onto Hindustan's expansive scaffolding. It would remain a great Mughal city and the cultural heart of the Punjab till 1748 when it was captured by the Afghans. Salim, who was travelling to Lahore with his father, would be particularly enchanted with the city and would live there many years when he became Padshah. His wife, Noor Jahan, is believed to have said; 'We have purchased Lahore with our soul; we have given our life and bought another Paradise.' Both Salim and Noor Jahan would be buried in Lahore, and Noor Jahan's family, especially, would cleave the city to their legacy through extensive architectural commissions.

Monserrate, arriving in Lahore in 1582, wrote of a lively and thriving city, fragrant with perfumes:

> This city is second to none, either in Asia or in Europe, with regard to size, population and wealth. It is crowded with merchants, who forgather there from all over Asia. In all these respects, it excels other cities, as also in the huge quantity of every kind of merchandise which is imported. Moreover there is no art or craft useful to human life which is not practised there. The population is so large that men jostle each other in the streets. The citadel alone, which is built of brickwork laid in cement, has a circumference of nearly three miles. Within this citadel is a bazaar which is protected against the sun in summer and the rain in winter by a high-pitched wooden roof—a design whose clever execution and practical utility should call for imitation. Perfumes are sold in this bazaar and the scent in the early morning is most delicious…most of the citizens are wealthy Brahmans and Hindus of every caste, especially Kashmiri. These Kashmiri[s] are bakers, eating-house keepers, and sellers of second-hand rubbish….